

Fogazzaro's Little World of the Past : Program Notes for an Italian "Classic"

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The Oxford Library of Italian Classics is conducted along canonical Italian lines; the selections are generally made within the area that would be familiar to the average Italian bourgeois, vaguely respectful of "national masterpieces" he never reads. Fogazzaro's *Piccolo mondo antico* ("The Little World of the Past," translated by W. J. Strachan, 1962) is not, as far as I know, on compulsory reading lists of secondary schools but certainly holds its own in textbooks and in the vague national conscience. It is still often accompanied by that tag, "the best Italian novel after Manzoni," which implies more or less overtly the notion that Fogazzaro is a writer in the Manzoni manner.

Actually, although both writers use narrative voices that are by and large traceable to the cultivated middle-class, Manzoni's style is so much more varied and subtle than Fogazzaro's, that the latter looks definitely shabby by comparison. Manzoni's celebrated humor, in the picturing of characters but not in any direct aping of their presumed speech, by contrast makes Fogazzaro's vernacular dialogue sound heavily provincial. True, both writers see their respective world from religious angles; but whereas Manzoni's humble hero and heroine have their destinies regulated by a Divine Providence about which they are hardly articulate, Fogazzaro's protagonists are middle-class or provincial nobility, making a great deal of their religious beliefs and disbeliefs, ambiguous and confused as these may be. In fact, the choice of focus possibly constitutes the deepest difference between Manzo-

ni and Fogazzaro as novelists; Fogazzaro's visual angle, if applied to the material of Manzoni's novel, would have to make the story hinge not on Renzo and Lucia as central characters but, say, on the Innominato.

The translations in the Oxford Library of Italian Classics are either new or re-arrangements of old ones. The Fogazzaro translation is completely new and the translator is particularly good (Mr. Strachan's anthology of Italian short stories, published several years ago, is probably still the best of its kind). In presenting the book series, no visible attempt is made at evaluation within our present literary context and taste. I suspect it might have been more exciting to have these Italian authors in English introduced by English or American writers and artists of today: Goldoni, say, by a stage director, or Fogazzaro by a present novelist. The introductions I have seen are either by Italians or by bona fide Italianists. Our book, Fogazzaro's *Piccolo mondo antico*, is introduced by Tommaso Gallarati Scotti, a supremely orthodox choice. Duke Gallarati Scotti was importantly connected with the religious *modernista* movement and knew Fogazzaro (who died in 1911) very well, being in fact something like a favorite disciple;¹ he is the author of a biography (Milan 1920) and the editor of a large anthology of Fogazzaro's letters (Milan 1940) which constitutes the thirteenth volume of the complete works in the Mondadori edition; the letters addressed to Gallarati Scotti himself are the largest single group.

Letters are as good a way as any to get a first view of a writer's world. The most significant common ground between Fogazzaro and his correspondents (other frequent ones are Monsignor Bonomelli, Filippo Crispolti, and several cultivated ladies) seems to be the intellectual and sentimental elaboration of religious piety. Not that the letters are by any means lacking in the type of information, public and private business, domestic

pleasantries or sorrowful references that are natural in letters exchanged between friends at a time when epistolary writing was still a current genre; but their striking feature remains the pervading evidence of religious habits of life and mind. To choose absolutely at random: on 4 October 1889, sending to a Miss Ellen Starbuck a flower, he would say: "It asks forgiveness for me by its name, *olea*, which means *olive*, peace, and by its melancholy perfume which goes to the soul. I confess my sin and then let the flower talk." (Incidentally, Franco in *Piccolo mondo antico* is a passionate floriculturist.) More seriously and typically, this is the close of a letter to Gallarati Scotti (4 October 1902, p. 487 in Gallarati Scotti's own published selection): "Believe, believe, that we are surrounded by dire enemy spirits to which God allows a certain power over us. Attribute to them every motion that is not good, and resist; and pray for me who am so unworthy of sermonizing in this manner, but do it perhaps as a gravely infirm person sadly counsels a companion less taken by the sickness. We are ready to leave here. The Valsolda during these first days of October has a sweet inexpressible melancholic beauty. I speak of it with sorrow but with so many dear recollections: your visit, so pious!, among the first."

We are here in the spiritual climate of Fogazzaro's novels. Indeed, on reading him after many years of total neglect, what strikes one still as the major distinguishing trait of this writer, singling him out as a virtually unique example among Italian novelists who have achieved major success since the unification of the country, is still the presence of religiosity as the chief factor in determining and qualifying actions and characters. This may be less unusual, or may even be frequent, in other literatures; in Italy, and especially in Italian fiction, it is awfully rare.

Piccolo mondo antico is a story of contrasted love and marriage on the background of the Risorgimento

(particularly, the years immediately following the heroic attempts and failures of 1848-49 and immediately preceding the 1859 war of independence) and I daresay that the patriotic historical context has been largely responsible for making the novel a *de rigueur* Italian "classic." However, there is little doubt that the love and marriage relationship between Luisa and Franco is the author's principal focus of interest, and it so happens that the major source of drama and motivation within that relationship is the contrast between the two, a contrast which they themselves, and the author, see and describe in terms of religious belief and practice.

This novel is always considered Fogazzaro's masterpiece. The novels that followed this one, and are related to it, especially *Il Santo*, owed their reputation and difficulties mainly to ideology; but the standard evaluation of *Piccolo mondo antico* is that this one novel represents the moment of happy balance between thought and image, between the debating of ideas and beliefs on the one side, and the authoritative presentation of flesh-and-blood characters and moving events on the other. That it may be Fogazzaro's most successful book in that sense—in other words, his most successful work of fiction—one can readily accept; still, the most important impression one derives from the book is that Fogazzaro is out to demonstrate a point: the superiority of Franco's warm and sentimental religiosity over Luisa's doubting philosophy which vacillates and even degenerates into occultism when tragedy strikes. However much Fogazzaro may have cherished his hero and heroine ("Franco is my father," he wrote in a letter of 23 November 1895 to a friend, Alfonso Garavaglio), and his numerous minor characters in the large and vernacular supporting cast, one feels that the sense of urgency and inevitability which compels a novelist to write was not, in his case, brought about by a vision of characters in action with their ambiguities and unpredictability but by the contemplation

of a doctrinal pattern—however substantially vague—which his characters and situations were made to fill out.

This is indirectly confirmed by the writer himself, for example in a letter partly published by Gallarati Scotti in his biography and quoted by Piero Nardi in an appendix to his edition of the novel.² On 5 October 1889—that is, almost six years before the novel was finished—Fogazzaro was writing in the following terms about his hero and heroine as they were taking shape, if shape is the word, in his mind: "*She* lives for this world, not in the sense of enjoying it; in the sense, rather, of a pity and justice exercising themselves *here* without preoccupations about the other life (in spite of apparent religious practices). *He* lives, in theory, for the next world, but in practice for the present one—to enjoy it, not badly but honestly. Their disagreement will manifest itself in a very grave form as they are confronted by a very grave fact which demands a decision. *She* will favor a decision suggested by justice and *he* will be for another decision, suggested not by human pity but a superior, religious charity: because *he* too will be violently recalled, by that event, to the logic of his own principles. After this point I see nothing but fog, and the confused image of a great, unexpected sorrow that heals."

What Fogazzaro had in mind as "the grave fact which demands a decision," testing his two protagonists' moral standards respectively based on "justice" (Luisa) and on a "superior, religious charity" (Franco), once he came down to the actual business of fiction writing was partly channeled into a relatively conventional and mechanical set of circumstances which constitute a kind of subplot in the novel. Family life, to the modern novel, is what court life was to classic tragedy; stories having to do with legacies and last wills are naturally numerous. In Fogazzaro's novel the hero and heroine are denied their rights and compelled to a life of virtual poverty through the opposition of Franco's grandmother, the

marble-cold Marchesa Maironi who, in the little world of the Valsolda region during the 1850's, rules over a coterie of vernacular sycophants and collaborationists. Not content with making her grandson and his wife poor, she has Austrian authorities persecute Uncle Piero, the epitome of a *naturaliter christiana* sort of goodness, in whose house Franco and Luisa have found shelter. Lombardy, where the story takes place, as well as Venetia where Fogazzaro was born, at the time of the action were part of the Austrian Empire; the Marchesa, being naturally on the side of conservatism and entrenched privilege, lives well within that social and political system while Franco is an Italian patriot and marries what to the Marchesa looks very much like the wrong girl. To the Risorgimento patriots the Marchesa represents the hated *austriacante* type while they, to the likes of her, are subversives.

Since the novel's vision is practically black-and-white, with the patriots white and the *austriacanti* black (generally petty hypocrites rather than straight sinister villains) it is not surprising that in the subplot having to do with family finance, the Marchesa should reveal herself as having behaved not only cruelly but also rather crookedly. The mechanical action hinges on the last will of Franco's grandfather, officially disappeared but secretly preserved by a well-meaning and ineffectual friend of the family. Franco rejects his wife's idea of "justice" (claiming their rights, exposing the Marchesa) and relentlessly exercises his "superior, religious charity." The outcome, eventually, will vindicate his attitude in the sense that the Marchesa will be reduced to frightened repentance; meanwhile, however, tragedy will have struck, the main theme of the book will have made its entrance, the "confused image of a great, unexpected sorrow that heals" eventually having coagulated, in Fogazzaro's mind, into the story's culminating episode, the drowning of Maria-Ombretta, the little daughter of the protagonists.

The heart-rending revelation of sorrow marks the moment of supreme alienation between husband and wife; their reaction to that event is the great test of their religious views: and this contrast, as we have indicated, is the main subject of the book. To Luisa's position (negation, sense of cosmic injustice) Franco opposes his conception of sorrow as a dreadful but ultimately healing experience. In a rather obvious fashion, the author connects this main theme to the "legacy" subplot: the little girl was drowning at the very moment her mother was waiting for the Marchesa in order to confront her and squarely denounce her in the name of a conception of "justice" which Franco had violently opposed. Franco's view, his instinctive "superior charity," his sentimental and religious fiber are presented as "right" in the end; he is the victor, the point of the story being that he draws moral energy from his bereavement.

Evidently Fogazzaro saw his novelist's function not only as entertainer but also as moral and religious teacher. In fact, his personal involvement with the ideas and attitudes which his characters embody is perhaps Fogazzaro's main distinguishing trait. It is therefore comprehensible that at the culminating point of his most reputed work he should have drawn clearly also from a very terrible personal experience of paternal sorrow. His own son, Mariano, a very gifted and promising young man, died of typhoid fever at twenty, in May of 1895. In August of that year Fogazzaro finished *Piccolo mondo antico* which came out in November. Although his work that summer was mainly one of copying and revising, the author himself said that the re-writing of crucial paragraphs about Franco's feelings on his little daughter's death in the chapter titled "Shadow and Dawn" (chapter 17 in the Strachan translation) was done "with the blood of the heart"; he "retouched them with tears," *con infinite ma dolcissime lacrime*.³ His own sorrow after his son's death followed then a sentimental and ideological pattern similar to that

of Franco; from early shock it was turned to "sorrow that heals," and Fogazzaro himself analysed this condition, for example in a letter of 17 June 1895 to his friend Filippo Crispolti, with astonishing clarity.⁴ To him there was something "very sweet" in his pain, which made it "precious"; it contained a "hidden gladness" (*segreta letizia*). Both his wife and himself, he writes, had lived in a state of "continuous trepidation for the moral health" of their son. They had trembled, fearing that "his religious feeling may not be strong enough to save him." Now, after the boy's particularly edifying death, the father's trepidation had been replaced by a superior serenity, accompanied by tears, *calde, larghe lacrime*. "I feel that he is my guide now . . . and perhaps trembles (*trepida*) for me as I trembled for him! Isn't there an infinite sweetness in this?" In the novel's passage where the hero is inspired by an analogous temper, and generally in the process of sublimating his pain, Franco, rather than representing the author's father, has become Fogazzaro himself.

In further life, Fogazzaro industriously produced novels of an increasingly ideological and doctrinal nature while pursuing something of a lay preacher's career; his peak as a novelist, at any rate, had been reached once and for all, a fact of which he seems to have been clearly aware.⁵ He lived the rest of his life highly honored and befriended in spite of some widely advertised difficulties with church authorities especially when his novel, *Il Santo*, was placed on the Index. Religiosity remained the main distinguishing trait of his public and private personality. He was made a senator of the Italian kingdom. He was very rich and surrounded by family affections and tender friendships. (His relatives' names, and those of several close friends, read like a roster of the nobility of his province, Vicenza; some of those names are still prominent in the Christian-Democratic circles of present-day Italy.) His momentary *alter ego* in the novel, Franco Maironi, of

course had lived in a different historical context (which the novelist had known only as a child and adolescent); he had had the chances for action that existed for a member of the patriotic middle-class in the decisive years of the Risorgimento. The novel contains episodes of political persecution, the police knocking at the door, the house being searched. Compared to similar situations in the experience of our century, Fogazzaro's scenes appear rather like amiable vignettes. This may partly mirror historical realities but is also due to Fogazzaro's point of view, basically domestic and provincial as far as the historical background is concerned; no important member of the ruling class is seriously analysed; his collaborationists are comic weaklings; his self-exiled patriots during Franco's period in Turin are on the whole presented in terms of the standard jocose "poor student" cliché, and his disguised patriots' escape is presented with overt farcical touches. It would be vastly misleading, I think, to consider this an important novel about the Risorgimento in the sense, say, that *War and Peace* is "about" Napoleon's Russian campaign. Which is perhaps one more way of saying that the only theme that really interests the author is his moral-religious one; in fact, as the hero is setting out to undertake important action and participate in his country's history, the novel comes to an end.

Nevertheless, it has been traditional to consider the interlocking of individual events and the patriotic-historical background as one of Fogazzaro's greatest achievements in *Piccolo mondo antico*.

After a fresh reading, this seems to me the most dangerously confused feature of the book; as an educational historical novel of ideas, its effects, if any, on further Italian generations can only have been negative. As everyone knows, the problem of "God and Country" acquires a special connotation in Italian history on account of the position of the Roman Catholic church within Italy itself. At the Franco Maironi stage of national events,

and afterwards, the Italian national problem, for good or ill, was to be faced politically also in terms of the Vatican state on the one side and the Italian state on the other. Fogazzaro presents the problem at the personal moral-religious level, and this presentation, inasmuch as *Piccolo mondo antico* is also a historical novel, tends to make him evade, or falsify, or at any rate considerably blur the issue. The befogging result is obtained by that very interlocking of the personal and the historical that admirers consider a great achievement. This is not to imply that the Franco Maironi confusion does not correspond to a possibly widespread psychological and cultural confusion in a certain type of upper and middle-class Italians.

Toward the end of chapter 17, as soon as his daughter has been sacrificed, as it were, to his mystic enlightenment, Franco's thoughts turn to the country: "He prayed and wept a long time, then he went out on to the terrace. The sky was growing light over the Galbiga and the mountains of Lake Como; dawn was at hand . . . To live, work, suffer, worship, aspire! That was the message of the light. To bear the living in one's arms, the dead in one's heart, to return to Turin, serve Italy, die for it! That was the message of this new dawn: Italy, dear mother! Franco clasped his hands together in eager anticipation." Three paragraphs below, the hero's position is faced somewhat more explicitly; this is in fact, I think, the key passage in the whole novel; it opposes Franco's view to his wife's temporary loss of faith: "He, a Christian, was contemplating an insurrection armed with wrath and weapons against other brothers in Christ for the love of one point on one tiny planet; she was contemplating rebellion in terms of a Liberation of the Universe. Her thought might seem more grandiose, her intellect the stronger. But He whom human generations learn to know better as they develop in civilization and wisdom; He who accepts the homage of each generation according to its capacity and gradually transforms and raises the ideals

of his peoples; He who when the time ripe turns even transitory and less noble ideals to good account for His government of this world; He, the spirit of Peace and Life who yet allows Himself to be called Lord God of Battles, had set the seal of His judgement on the face of the woman and on the face of the man. As day dawned, Franco's brow seemed radiant with an inner light . . ."

The "transitory and less noble ideals" (in Strachan's translation; Fogazzaro's adjectives are *inferiori e perituri*) are obviously the ones caused by "love of one point on one tiny planet," the unification and liberation of the country, the Risorgimento ideals. While Fogazzaro's view is perfectly orthodox at some cosmic and religious level, its apparent clarity may engender a certain amount of confusion once we see the problem in terms of the practical events of history, with which, in one way or another, the novel is also concerned. At that level the problem is left dangling. The same mystic-sentimental charge animates Franco the believer and Franco the citizen, and that is about all. He seems scarcely equipped to face the problems that the presence and authority of his Church—representing the nobler and not transitory ideals of divine government—would create for the realization and strengthening of "one point on one tiny planet," his country.

Those problems, in fact, remained quite open, and Fogazzaro's activities as a prominent citizen of the new kingdom and as a religious debater did not contribute much to their solution. Fogazzaro's intense and emotive sincerity always somehow attracts our interest; yet his image, within the culture of his time, and in spite of popularity, is marked by a sense of specialness—the feeling is that he somehow does not centrally belong to the Italian temper, whatever that may be. He and other intellectuals of the *modernista* movement, for instance, found themselves at odds with ecclesiastical authorities on the one side, while the liberals on the other reacted to

their difficulties by saying that that was strictly internal church business.⁶ Fogazzaro's popularity was perhaps always quite shallow. The truth probably is that important religious debate is pretty foreign to Italian cultural life and to the interests of the Italian public, so that even Fogazzaro, however able he may have been in turning thought into vague emotion, was more than that public could take. Thus Franco Maironi is hardly a national hero and *Piccolo mondo antico* hardly a national "classic." It is known, rather than read. Finally it may be interesting to observe that in the Italy of today, whose government class, to a greater extent than ever, is under relevant church influence, there is hardly a trace of a Fogazzaro revival.

NOTES

1. In these brief "program notes" for one particular novel, I hardly touch on Fogazzaro's cultural, religious and political milieu. Useful hints for further reading may be found in such recent publications as Giovanni Spadolini, *L'opposizione cattolica*, 4th ed., Florence 1961, esp. pp. 750-751, and Michele Ranchetti, *Cultura e riforma religiosa nella storia del modernismo*, Turin 1963, pp. 117-129. 173-183 and *passim*.
2. Milan 1930, vol. 5 of the Mondadori edition; p. 529. On pp. 531-532 Nardi quotes *in toto* the letter to Garavaglio mentioned above, in which Fogazzaro, besides the allusion to his father, offers further identifications for other characters.
3. Cf. Ottorino Morra, *Fogazzaro nel suo piccolo mondo (dai carteggi familiari)* Cappelli Editore 1960, pp. 443-444.
4. The letter is published in the Gallarati Scotti selection, pp. 346-347.
5. See for example Morra, *op. cit.*, p. 442. "
6. For a clear account see the recent A. C. Jemolo, *Chiesa e stato in Italia negli ultimi cento anni*, Turin 1963, esp. pp. 377-379.

Publishing in Milan and in Italy

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Italy is living in one of the most interesting phases of its history, a phase of fervid and disorderly developments; one notes a great leap forward, a simultaneous reappearance of many contradictions and strains which are difficult and sometimes impossible to resolve. The country is ancient and feudal in many of its ways; in other ways it is very modern, and boasts of the conquests of the new capitalism. In Italy, choosing an example at random (and let us take as an example the very symbol of well-being in the West—the automobile), the diffusion of the automobile has been very rapid and astonishing in the last few years; in a short time European levels have been reached and by now 20% of Italian families own a car (to be compared, according to the data furnished by the institute "Misura," with 26% in Germany and Holland, 30% in Belgium, 32% in Great Britain, and 40% in France). The statistics are encouraging, even if, unfortunately, in their generous universality they conceal many contradictions. It is like the fable of the chicken, there is one for everybody according to the statistics, but